



Half Life 2: The Way of Water

Version 1.0

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Document Revisions Table

Version	Description	Requestor	Date
1.0	Initial Document	Professor Brandon Stephens	10/27/2025

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Level Summary

Quick Summary

When Gordon Freeman left Black Mesa East for Ravenholm, a sealed research area (Sublevel 7) beneath the surface was abandoned in an explosion. Players take on the role of Freeman with a small team, tasked with infiltrating the abandoned underwater research area, retrieving crucial data, and escaping.

Level Feature Overview

Category	Sub-Category	Feature List
Gameplay Themes		- Puzzle and combat - Conductor and water
Player	Player Weapons	- Crossbar - Crossbow - Phycannon
	Player Skills/Abilities	Swim
AI	Enemies	- Zombie/Headcrab - Poison Zombie - Fast Zombie
	Friendlylies	NPC_Friendly*2
Challenges	Obstacles/Hazards	Water and electricity traps
	New/Unique Gameplay	Water and electricity, oxygen and underwater escape
Context	Location in Game	Submerged research facility beneath Nova Prospekt or along the coastal highway
	Challenge Fit in Game	Water Puzzle
	Narrative Fit	- Freeman is sent to recover lost Combine experimental data from a flooded lab - Accident causes containment breach and rising flood; Freeman must escape before total collapse
	Basic Backstory / Results Info	- Facility was conducting underwater weapon-energy research - After retrieving the data, reactor overload triggers explosions - Player escapes via flooding shaft / tunnel to the surface - Ending shows data being transferred successfully
Aesthetics	Major Visual Themes	Underwater
	Setting/Mood	Creepy/Dark

Development Schedule

Milestone	Date
LDD	10/26/2025

Whitebox	11/2/2025
Initial Gameplay	11/9/2025
Gameplay Complete	11/16/2025
Aesthetics	11/23/2025
Launch	12/02/2025

Level Overview

Overview Map

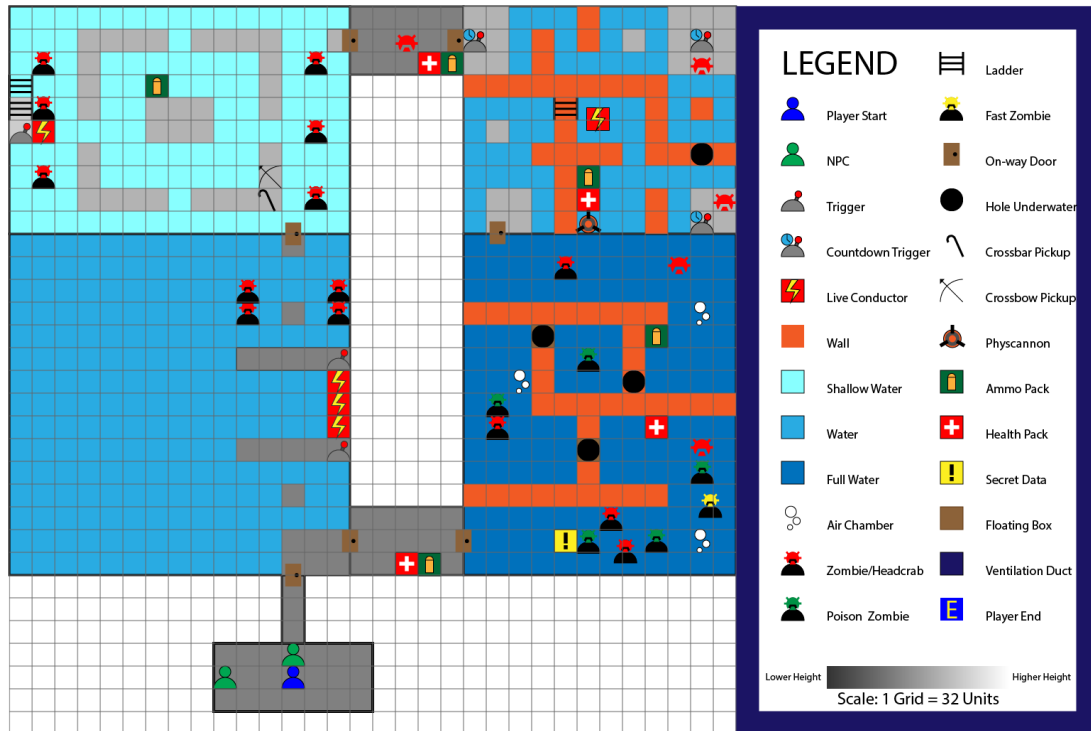


Figure 1: Overview Map

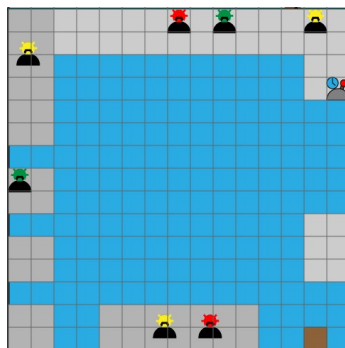


Figure 2: Room 1 2nd Floor



Figure 3: Room 1 3rd Floor

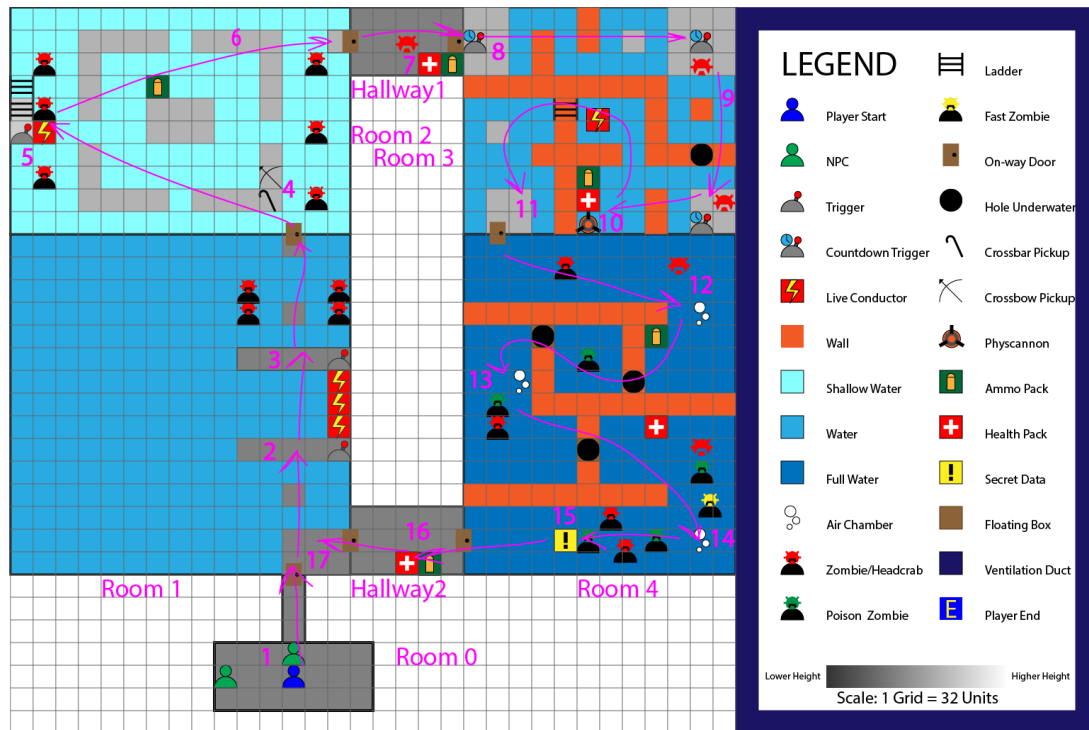


Figure 4: Overview Map with Annotation

Map Label	Gameplay Summary
Room 0	Submarine, starting location, teammates explain the level objectives
Room 1	The first room faces a water and electricity puzzle
Room 2	First battle room
Hallway 1	hallway with headcrab jump scare
Room 3	The first room has a countdown trigger puzzle
Room 4	A completely flooded room, requiring players to manage oxygen and advance in the dark
Hallway 2	Resting point, environmental narrative shows that the underwater base is about to collapse
Room 1	Return to room 1
Room 1 2nd Floor	As the water rises to floor 2
Room 1 3rd Floor	As the water rises, you reach floor 3 and finally escape from the collapsed underwater base.

Level Details

Detail Maps

Room 0 Map

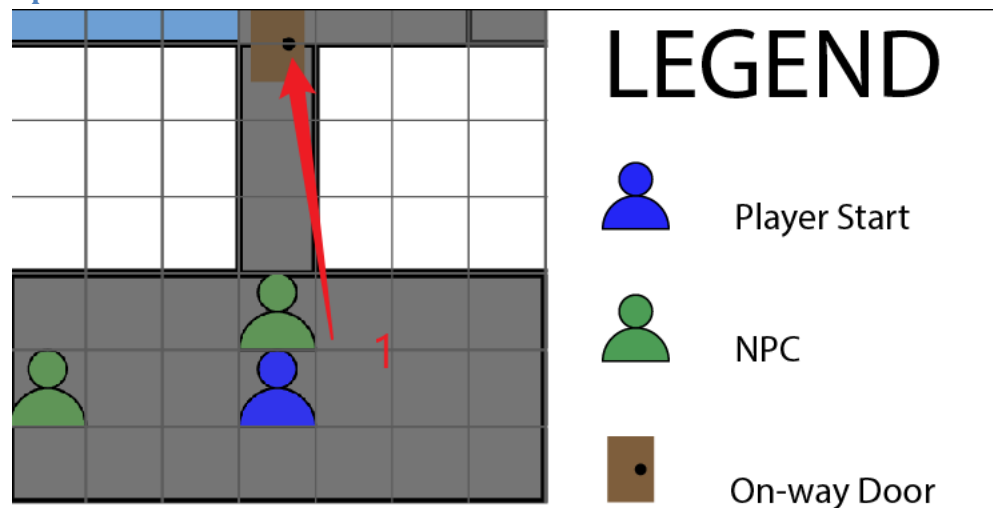
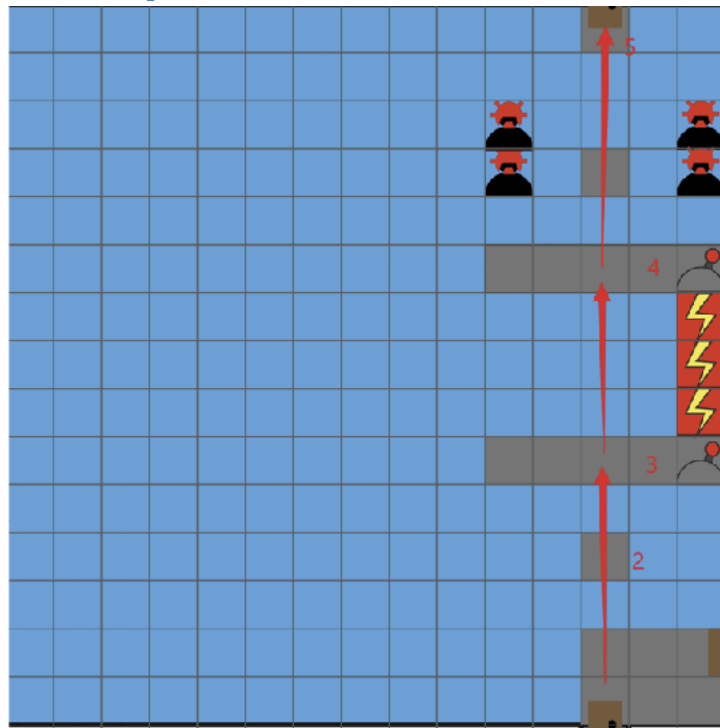


Figure 5: Room 0 Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
1	The player begins the game on a submarine. An NPC teammate explains their next mission: to dive into a secret laboratory that has exploded underwater, retrieve secret data, and escape. They also say they'll be waiting there. Once the submarine docks with the laboratory, the player can exit.	

Room 1 Map



LEGEND



Zombie/Headcrab



Trigger



Live Conductor



Water

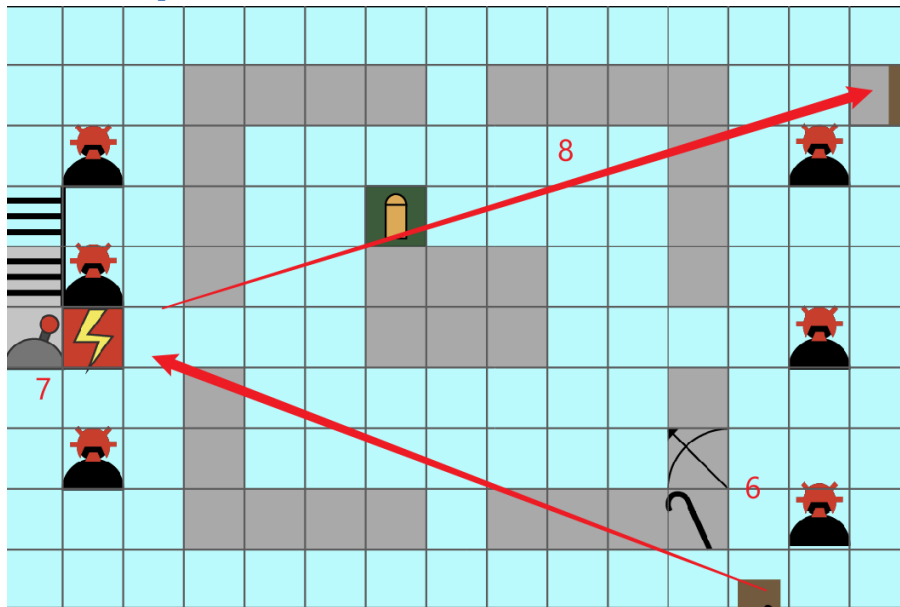


On-way Door

Figure 6: Room 1 Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
2	Jump between high places and floating objects, and avoid electrified water bodies	
3	Turn off the trigger to turn off the current in the water and swim to the platform on the other side.	Whole water body as one with electric
4	Turn on the trigger again and use the current in the water to kill a group of approaching zombies.	
5	Jump from the high platform again to reach the other side of the room	Zombies * 4

Room 2 Map



LEGEND

-  Zombie/Headcrab
-  Trigger
-  Live Conductor
-  On-way Door
-  Shallow Water
-  Crossbar Pickup
-  Crossbow Pickup
-  Ammo Pack

Figure 7: Room 2 Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
6	Pick up the crossbar, crossbow, and fight the zombies in the shallow water.	Zombies * 6
7	Climb up the ladder, turn on the switch, electrify the shallow water and kill all zombies	
8	Because the water is electrified, jump from the high platform to the room exit	

Hallway 1 Map

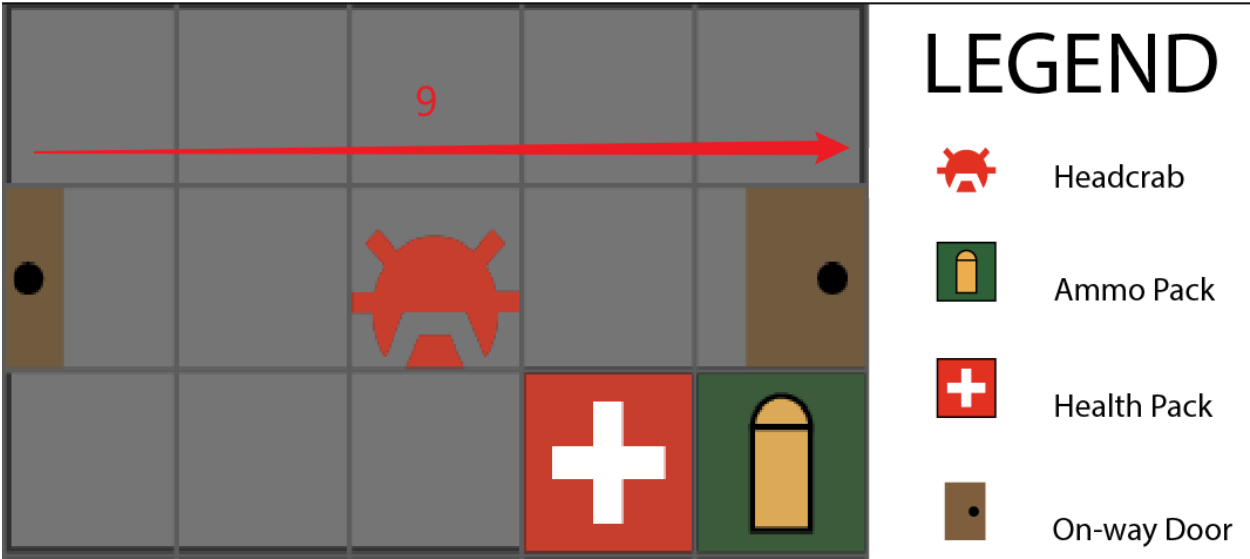


Figure 8: Hallway 1 Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
9	Jump scare, a headcrab will suddenly drop from the ventilation duct above the player and attack them.	

Room 3 Map

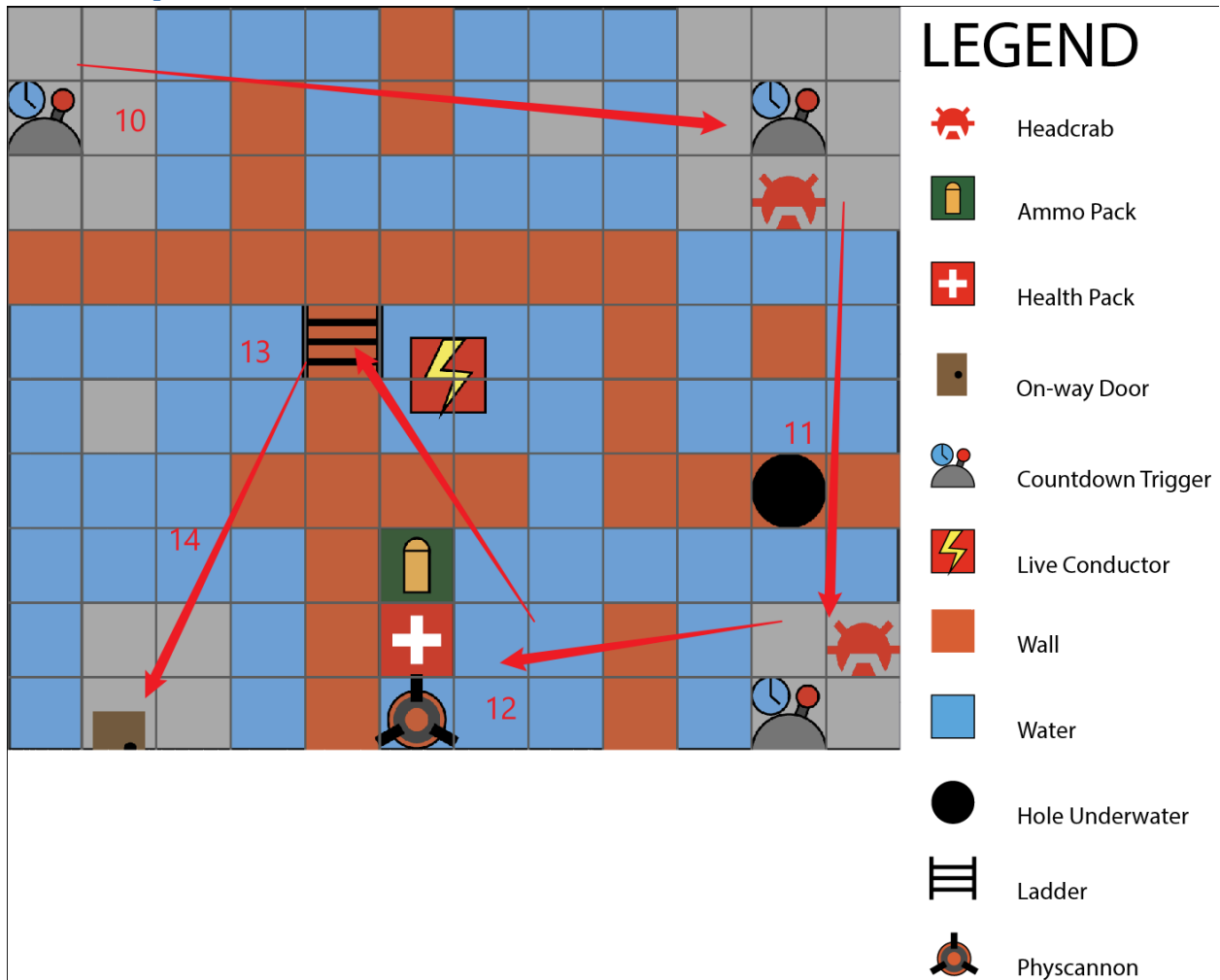


Figure 9: Room 3 Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
10	Countdown trigger: When the player presses it, the water stops flowing and a countdown of 8 seconds begins. After 8 seconds, the water immediately turns on. The player must cross the water to reach the next safe platform within the time limit.	Headcrab * 1
11	Players need to dive to find a hole in the corner of the wall to reach the next safe platform	Headcrab * 1
12	Players get phycannon	
13	Players need to climb ladders to cross obstacles	
14	Players need to use phycannon in the water to clear obstacles to move forward	Physical interactive stuff in the water

Room 4 Map

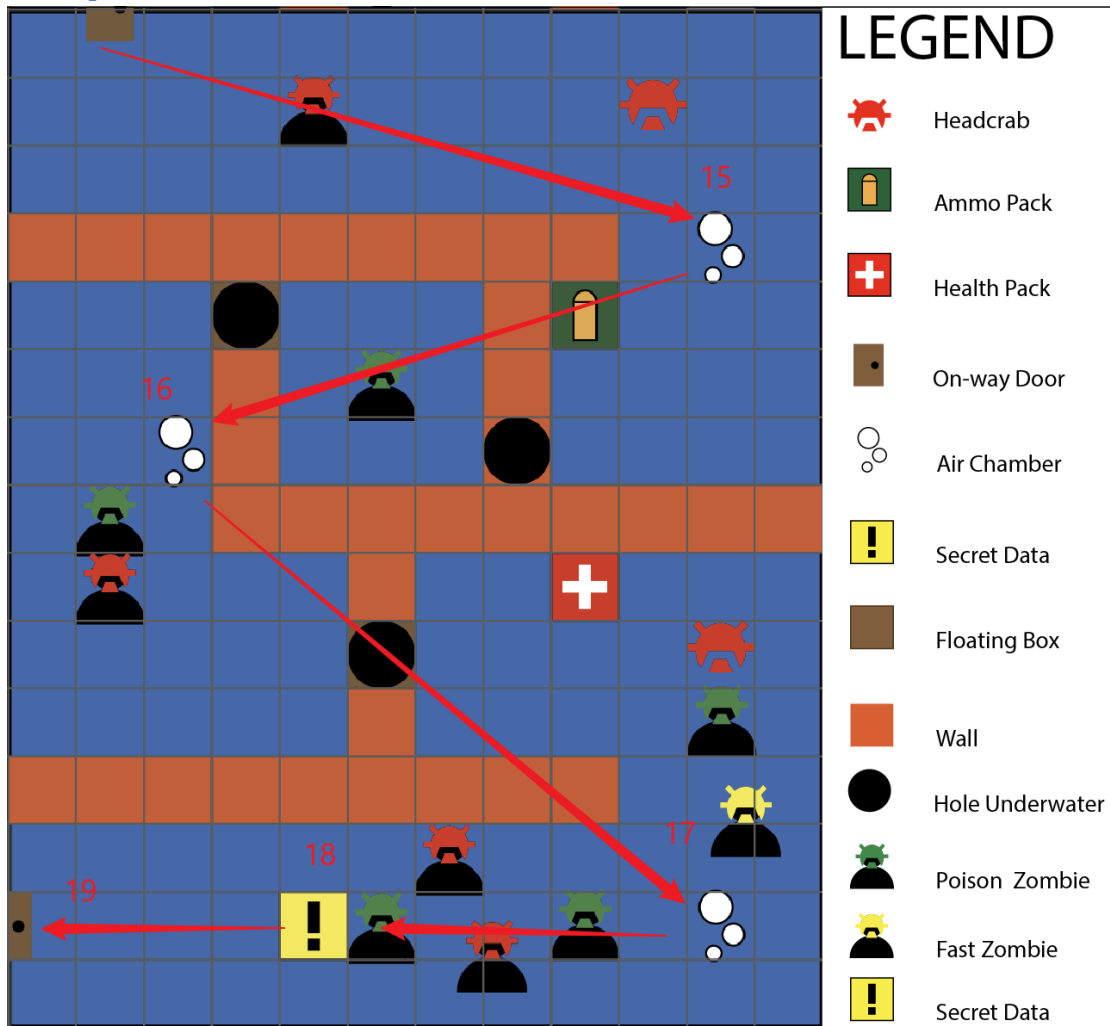


Figure 10: Room 4 Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
15	Navigate a water-filled room in the dark and reach the next air chamber before running out of oxygen.	Zombie *1
16	Use the physcannon to move the object blocking the road and go through the hole to the next air chamber. The Poison Zombie appears.	Poison Zombie *1
17	Go through the hole and the monsters to the third air chamber, where a new type of monster, the Fast Zombie, appears.	Poison Zombie *1 Zombie *1
18	Get secret data on the terminal	Poison Zombie *1 Fast Zombie *1
19	Leave this room before the oxygen runs out	Poison Zombie *2 Zombie *2

Hallway 2 Map

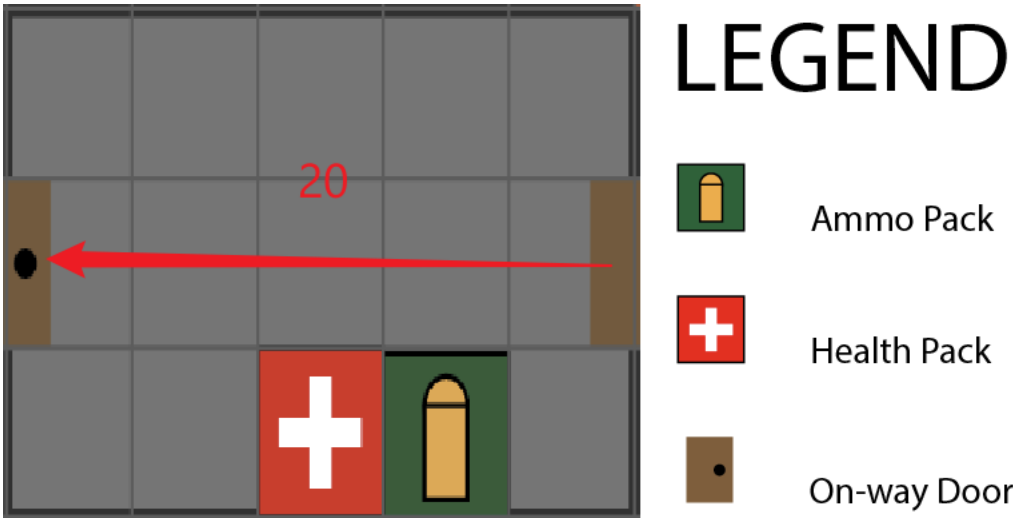


Figure 11: Hallway 2 Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
20	Cross the hallway and get supplies. Currently, there are obvious signs of water leakage in the environment.	

Room 1 Map

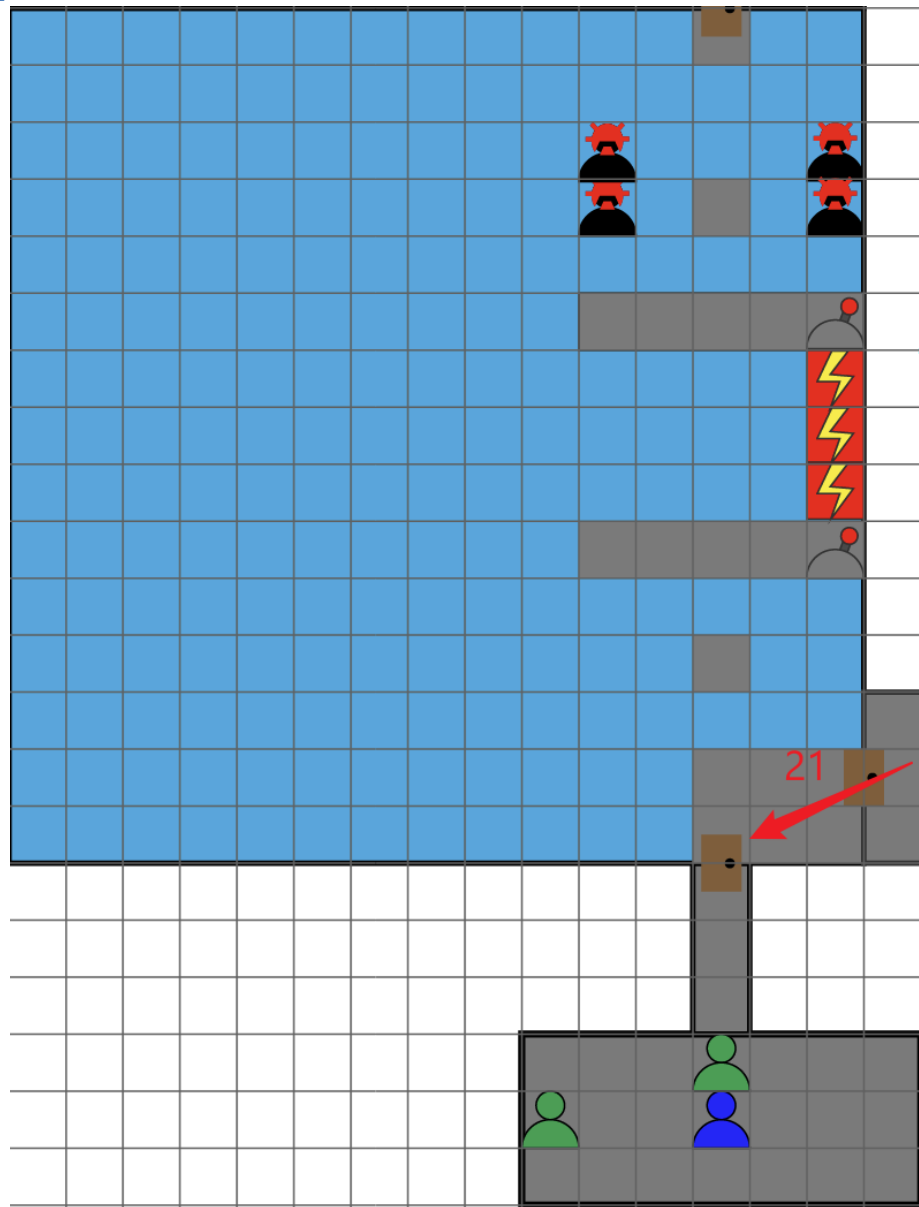
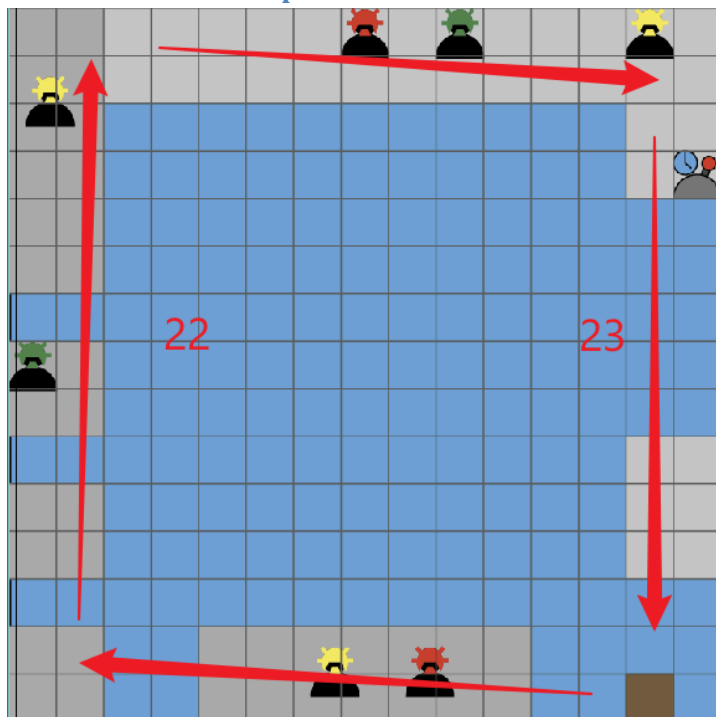


Figure 12: Room 1 Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
21	Returning to room 1 again, the water level has risen. To avoid the electrified water body, the player can only stand on the floating box. The NPC teammate across the door said that the door can no longer be opened from this side. The player needs to go up and swim directly back to the surface from above the base to meet up with teammates.	

Room 1 2nd Floor Map**LEGEND**

Zombie/Headcrab



Poison Zombie



Fast Zombie

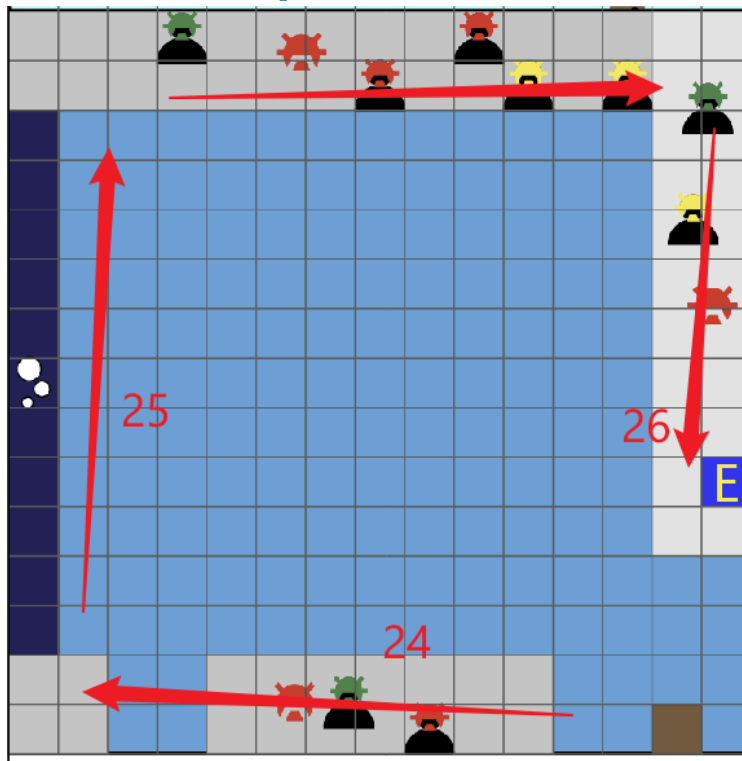


Countdown Trigger

Figure 13: Room 1 2nd Floor Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
22	As the electrified water level rises, players need to escape upward along a spiral path while clearing out enemies.	Zombies *2 Poison Zombies *2 Fast Zombies*3
23	Use the timer switch to swim to the safe platform on the other side of the water	

Room 1 3rd Floor Map



LEGEND



Zombie/Headcrab



Poison Zombie



Fast Zombie



Ventilation Duct



Player End

Figure 14: Room 1 3rd Floor Map

Map Label / Stage	Event Summary	Event Details
24	Players continue to spiral out of control	Headcrab *1 Zombie *1 Poison Zombie *1
25	Players must activate the countdown trigger and continue to move forward in a ventilation duct filled with water, using the air chamber to breathe in the middle.	
26	After passing the last wave of enemies, the player reaches the end and reunites with teammates safely, and the level ends.	Zombies *2 Poison Zombies *2 Fast Zombies *3 Headcrab *2

Skill Progression Chart

	Start	Room 0	Room 1					Room2					Hallway 1					Room 3					Room 4					Hallway 2		Room 1: Re				
		1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27						
Player Skills	Walk/Run	E	E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H						
	Jump	E	E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H						
	Swim				E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H						
	Climb														E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H		H	H	H	H	H					
	Duck															E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H		H	H	H	H	H					
Weapons	Crossbar						E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H					
	Crossbow						E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H					
	Gravity Gun															E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H					
Enemies	Headcrab/Zombie						E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H					
	Fast Zombie																E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H					
	Poison Zombie																		E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H					
Others	Water		E	M	H	H																												
	Shallow Water						E	M	H	H	H	H	H																					
	Full Water																	E	M	H	H	H	H											
	Live Conductor				E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H						
	Trigger				E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H						
	Countdown Trigger													E	M	H	H	H	H	H	H	H	H											
	Air Chamber																	E	M	H	H	H	H											
	0:00	0:25	0:50	1:15	1:40	2:05	2:30	2:55	3:20	3:45	4:10	4:35	5:00	5:25	5:50	6:15	6:40	7:05	7:30	7:55	8:20	8:45	9:10	9:35	10:00	10:25	10:50	11:15						

Figure 15: Skill Progression Chart

Aesthetic References

A dilapidated underwater Combine laboratory, reeling from an accident, is filled with flickering lights, leaking pipes, and floating debris. A cold blue hue dominates, contrasting starkly with the red emergency lights and gleaming Combine technology. Muffled alarms and the gurgling of water echo through the flooded halls, creating a tense, claustrophobic atmosphere, perpetually leaking and on the verge of collapse.

Water Chamber



Figure 16: Water Chamber

Underwater Chamber



Figure 17: Underwater Chamber

References



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- [2] "Half-Life 2 - Valve Developer Community," *Valvesoftware.com*, 2022. https://developer.valvesoftware.com/wiki/Half-Life_2
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- [5] C. O'Falt, "'Mission: Impossible 8': Inside How They Shot Underwater Submarine," *IndieWire*, Jun. 06, 2025. <https://www.indiewire.com/features/craft/mission-impossible-8-how-they-shot-underwater-submarine-1235130251/> (accessed Oct. 26, 2025).

Appendices

Appendix A: New Skills / Gameplay Mechanics

Conductors and water

Conductors are charged. When water meets a conductor, the same area of water will become charged, and players, enemies, and other creatures that meet it will be harmed.

Trigger

Players can turn the conductor on or off by pressing.

Countdown Trigger

When the player presses it, the corresponding conductor will be de-charged for 8 seconds and will be charged again after the countdown ends.

Appendix B: Context Detail

General Context

Backstory

When a secret underwater research facility explodes, Freeman is tasked with retrieving the crucial data core left behind before the reactor completely collapses.

Aftermath

Freeman escapes the collapsing facility through a flooded escape shaft and surfaces near the shore, as the entire building implodes behind him. The critical data he obtains will be of great help to humanity's cause.

Appendix C: Character Descriptions

NPC 1: Nobody 1

Description	N/A
Background	N/A
Goals/Motivation	Drive the submarine to send Freeman to the underwater base and pick him up after he completes his mission
Personality/Archetype	N/A
Relationships	Teammate

NPC 2: Nobody 2

Description	N/A
Background	N/A
Goals/Motivation	Assist two teammates in a submarine, explain the task to Freeman
Personality/Archetype	N/A

Relationships	Teammate
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Appendix F: Key Asset Needs

Description	Type	Priority
Water Texture	Texture	High
Glass Texture	Texture	High
Lab Style Texture	Texture	High